

lion with 1.08 million on CPU and 1.38 million on GPU. The 3D Mark Stress Test delivered a best loop of 19,582, a lowest loop of 15,654 and stability of 79.9%. The CPU throttle test averaged 330K GIPS with 76% stability. Long story short, this phone is brutally fast.

But does it heat up? Well, during benchmarking, yes, it did get warm. But so do other smartphones too, that are powered by the Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 5. What's worth noting is that in real-world use, I've never felt it become uncomfortably hot. I've been using it daily for navigation on Android Auto, watching videos late into the night, shooting loads of photos and even gaming, and the phone at most becomes lukewarm. Compared to how some Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 5 phones struggled this year, the iQOO 15 actually manages thermals fairly well.



GROWN UP SOFTWARE

The iQOO 15 runs OriginOS 6 based on Android 16, and this is probably the most confident software experience iQOO has ever shipped. It no longer feels like a skin trying too hard. It feels mature. Animations are smooth, the interface feels clean, and the overall experience is genuinely pleasant.

You get all the expected AI features: Google's Gemini, summary tools, AI notes, photo enhancements, and whatnot. But what really stood out for me, as part of the software package, is Office Kit. It lets you connect your phone to your PC seamlessly for file sharing, screen mirroring, note syncing and general productivity. For those who use an iPhone with a Mac would understand where I am coming from.

It actually works without drama, and that alone makes it a value-add feature rather than just a checklist item.

A DEPENDABLE CAMERA

For the first time, iQOO's camera system feels properly flagship-ready. You get three 50MP sensors at the back: a primary camera, an ultra-wide, and a 3x periscope telephoto. That periscope lens alone is a massive upgrade over previous iQOO flagships.

Daylight photos are excellent with high detail, natural colours and well-managed dynamic range. Now, there is a bit of processing going on in photos, but it is something that I personally prefer as the photos shot on this phone look quite vibrant. Portraits are a highlight, especially with the 3x lens. Edge detection is clean, background blurs naturally, and skin tones are pleasing.



Low-light performance is solid too, thanks to the software's ability to control highlights and keep noise in check. The main camera performs best here, while the ultra-wide and telephoto do show some noise in very dark scenes, but nothing alarming.

The 32MP selfie camera delivers sharp, bright photos with good HDR in daylight. Occasionally, colours can look slightly off or overly sharpened indoors, but most people will be more than happy with it. Video support goes all the way up to 8K at 30fps and 4K at 60fps on the rear cameras, with good stabilisation and dynamic range. Even the front camera can do 4K at 60fps, which content creators will appreciate.

Is it better than camera-focused phones like the Vivo X300 Pro? Not

quite. But as part of a performance-first flagship and for its price, the iQOO 15's camera system holds its own.

VERDICT

The iQOO 15 feels like a defining moment for the brand. It is no longer just chasing performance numbers or trying to undercut rivals on price. Instead, it is finally trying to stand confidently among the top Android flagships. There's the absurdly bright 2K display, the performance is rock-solid, the battery life is dependable, and the camera system is surprisingly capable. Basically, what I am trying to imply is that the phone delivers where it truly matters in daily use. It feels refined, powerful, and, for the most part, well thought through.

Recalling my conversation with iQOO's CEO, Nipun Marya, he made it clear that pricing this year was driven not just by rising component costs, but by the number of upgrades in the iQOO 15. The new chipset, the periscope camera, wireless charging, the silicon-carbon battery, and the list goes on.

Of course, there's no denying that the price hike is real, and at this level, expectations rise sharply. But the iQOO 15 is a well-rounded, no-compromise flagship smartphone that finally feels confident playing in the big leagues.

—Aman Rashid

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 5 | GPU: Adreno 840 | RAM: 12 GB, 16 GB LPDDR5X | Storage 256 GB, 512 GB UFS 4.1 | OS: OriginOS 6, Android 16 | Display: 6.85-inch LTPO OLED, 1440 x 3168 pixels, HDR10+, Dolby Vision | Refresh Rate: 1-144 Hz | IP Rating: IP68/IP69 | Cameras: 50 MP (primary) + 50 MP (periscope) + 50 MP (ultra-wide) | Selfie Camera: 32 MP | Video: Up to 8K at 30 fps | Battery Capacity: 7,000 mAh | Charging: 100W (wired), 40W (wireless)

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